proportion of these were in managerial and professional occupations with a median income of more than $27,000. Many of the best of the new jobs went to women and minorities. During those six years, the median income for American families increased twelve percent, compared with a decline of 10.5 percent during the previous decade. The nation's real gross national product (the value of all goods and services produced in the United States, adjusted for inflation) went up twenty-seven percent; manufacturing production went up thirty-three percent. American workers became more productive each hour they worked and made their employers more competitive in world markets.

We got government out of the way and began the process of giving the economy back to the people, but I don't take credit: The American people did it themselves, responding to incentives inherent in the free enterprise system. I watched in wonder and awe as they responded and excelled and produced. There is no limit to what a proud, free people can achieve.

With the tax cuts of 1981 and the Tax Reform Act of 1986, I'd accomplished a lot of what I'd come to Washington to do.

But, on the other side of the ledger, cutting federal spending and balancing the budget, I was less successful than I wanted to be. This was one of my biggest disappointments as president. I just didn't deliver as much to the people as I'd promised.

I never thought we could cut costs so fast that we'd balance the budget overnight. I knew it would take time. There were too many programs that people based their lives and businesses on; you couldn't pull the rug out from under all of them at once. But I wanted to cut more of the waste that had accumulated in government like flab around the waist of a middle-aged man.

I didn't come to Washington with stars in my eyes, thinking it would be easy. I'd been through the same kind of